MODULE 24 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL BLOCKS

Exam mechanics and question formats

The exam's format and rules, every question type and how to approach it, timing, and what to do when Python 3.14 and the exam disagree.

BLOCKS all four FOCUS the exam itself MODULE 24 of 28

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Thirty questions, forty minutes, seventy per cent to pass, and **no notes of any kind**. Everything you trace on the day, you trace in your head.

The exam in facts

ITEM	DETAIL
Version	PCEP-30-02, active. PCEP-30-03 is listed as in development.
Questions and time	30 questions in 40 minutes, plus a 5 minute NDA and tutorial
Passing score	70%. Items can carry different points, up to 40 each
Delivery	TestNow, online and proctored, through the Python Institute
Retakes	After a 7 day wait, with no limit on attempts
Validity	5 years. Cost from 69 US dollars

BEFORE YOU BOOK

Before you book, check the version code on your voucher. If PCEP-30-03 is live, check its syllabus against this course.

ALL BLOCKS / WHERE THE MARKS ARE

Four blocks, thirty questions

BLOCK	WEIGHT	QUESTIONS	COVERED IN
1: Fundamentals	18%	7	modules 1 to 5
2: Control flow	29%	8	modules 6 to 10
3: Data collections	25%	7	modules 11 to 15
4: Functions and exceptions	28%	8	modules 16 to 21

ON THE EXAM

Blocks 2 and 4 together are more than half the exam. Both are mostly tracing.

Every format the exam can use

FORMAT	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE	APPROACH
Single-select	four options, one right	three passes: grammar, run, output
Multi-select	choose two, or choose three	judge each option on its own
Gap fill, code fill	a blank inside the code	try each option in the gap
Code insertion	pick the line that gives a stated output	run each option against the output
Drag and drop, sort	put items or lines in order	fix the first and last positions first
Interactive, scenario	a short task described in words	find the decision, then the rule

Multi-select: every option is its own question

- Decide **true or false for each option separately**, then pick exactly the number asked.
- Do not look for a pattern. The right options rarely share a theme.
- If more options seem true than you are asked for, one of them breaks a rule: find it.
- Count your selections before moving on. Choose two means two.

Try each option in place, grammar first

GAP FILL

What completes the code?

```
1  i = 0
2  ___ i < 3:
3      print(i, end=" ")
4      i += 1
```

Expected: 0 1 2. while works; if prints only 0; for and elif are SyntaxErrors.

CODE INSERTION

Which line gives this output?

```
1  nums = [1, 2, 3]
2  # insert line here
3  print(total)
```

Output 6: sum(nums). max is 3, nums[-1] * 3 is 9, len is 3.

ON THE EXAM

Eliminate on grammar first, it is fastest. Then trace only the options that are left.

Drag and drop, and sort

- Fix the ends first: what must come first, and what must come last.
- For code lines: a def before its call, a variable assigned before it is read, consistent indentation.
- For operator priority, use the real order: ** , unary, * / // %, + -, comparisons, not, and, or.
- Re-read the finished order as code, top to bottom, before moving on.

Rules of the online exam that change how you work

- **No notes of any kind**: no paper, no whiteboard, nothing written.
- **No scheduled breaks.** You stay seated and in view of the camera throughout.
- Full screen, one monitor, no other tabs, no phone or smartwatch in the room.
- A quiet, well-lit room where you are alone. A webcam and microphone are required.
- The score shown at the end is preliminary until the session has been reviewed.

About 80 seconds a question

QUESTION KIND	TYPICAL TIME	HOW TO KEEP IT THERE
Definition or recognition	20 to 40 seconds	answer and move on
Short output trace	60 to 80 seconds	three passes, grammar first
Loop or recursion trace	90 to 120 seconds	shortcuts: stop minus start, multiply or add
Choose two	60 to 90 seconds	one true or false judgement per option

EXAM TECHNIQUE

The quick questions pay for the long ones. If a trace runs long, choose using the method, and keep moving.

Turning this course's habits into mental ones

- Every time this course said write it down, do exactly that while studying.
- Then repeat the same question without paper, saying each value to yourself.
- Track as few things as possible: usually one variable and a count.
- Use shortcuts instead of full traces where a rule exists: ranges, nested loops, the first true branch.
- Take the three practice papers in this course without writing anything down.

When current Python and the exam disagree

WHAT CHANGED	PYTHON 3.14	ANSWER ON THE EXAM
`except A, B:` without brackets	legal (PEP 758)	choose the bracketed form
`return` inside `finally`	SyntaxWarning (PEP 765)	it still works: the warning changes nothing
error message wording	several reworded	answer by the exception's name
soft keywords `match`, `case`, `_`, `type`	legal names	there are still 35 keywords

ON THE EXAM

The exam was written for the classic rules. Where they differ, the classic rule is the safe answer.

Where study material can mislead you

- Logical **not** sits below every comparison, not beside unary minus (module 4).
- Only **one** except branch can run for an exception (module 21).
- For a string, the exam treats s[:] as a copy; CPython may return the same object (module 15).
- Certification lasts 5 years. Some third-party sites wrongly say it never expires.

A short checklist

- Check your voucher's exam version, and the current syllabus, on pythoninstitute.org.
- Run the TestNow equipment check: browser, webcam, microphone, a stable connection.
- Practise in a real interpreter: Python, IDLE, or the free Edube sandbox.
- Optional: the official PCEP-30-02 practice test is sold separately.
- Take this course's three practice papers, paper-free, before you book.

What to carry into the exam

- 30 questions, 40 minutes, 70% to pass. **No notes**, no breaks.
- About 80 seconds a question: quick ones pay for long traces.
- Choose N: judge each option separately, pick exactly N.
- Gaps and insertions: grammar first, then trace what is left.
- Where Python 3.14 and the exam differ, give the classic answer.

Which line, inserted at the comment, makes the program print 6?

```
1  nums = [1, 2, 3]
2  # insert line here
3  print(total)
```

EXPECTED OUTPUT

```
6
```

A `total = sum(nums)`

B `total = max(nums)`

C `total = nums[-1] * 3`

D `total = len(nums)`

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which line, inserted at the comment, makes the program print 6?

```
1  nums = [1, 2, 3]
2  # insert line here
3  print(total)
```

EXPECTED OUTPUT

```
6
```

A `total = sum(nums)`

1 + 2 + 3 is 6.

B `total = max(nums)`

The largest element is 3.

C `total = nums[-1] * 3`

*The last element is 3, and 3 * 3 is 9.*

D `total = len(nums)`

Three elements: 3.

THE SIGNAL

For code insertion, evaluate every option against the output. Do not stop at the first plausible one.

Which keyword fills the gap so the program prints 0 1 2?

```
1  i = 0
2  ___ i < 3:
3      print(i, end=" ")
4      i += 1
```

A if

B for

C while

D elif

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which keyword fills the gap so the program prints 0 1 2?

```
1  i = 0
2  ___ i < 3:
3      print(i, end=" ")
4      i += 1
```

A `if`

Legal, but runs the block once: prints 0 only.

B `for`

for needs name in sequence. SyntaxError.

C `while`

Repeats while i < 3: prints 0 1 2.

D `elif`

elif cannot start a statement. SyntaxError.

THE SIGNAL

Grammar removed two options instantly. Tracing decided between the last two.

> The operators are: and, **, ==, not

Which order lists these operators from highest to lowest priority?

A `** not == and`

B `not ** == and`

C `== ** and not`

D `** == not and`

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which order lists these operators from highest to lowest priority?

A `** not == and`

Puts not above ==. not sits below every comparison.

B `not ** == and`

The bank's mistake: not grouped with unary minus, at the top.

C `== ** and not`

*** is above every comparison, and not is above and.*

D `** == not and`

Power, then comparisons, then not, then and.

THE SIGNAL

Arithmetic, then comparisons, then not, then and, then or.

> These statements are about the PCEP-30-02 online exam session.

Which two statements are true? (Choose two.)

A. You may write working notes on scrap paper during the exam

B. The exam has 30 questions in 40 minutes, plus a short NDA and tutorial

C. The passing score is 70%

D. There is a scheduled break halfway through

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which two statements are true? (Choose two.)

A You may write working notes on scrap paper during the exam

The testing policies prohibit notes of any kind.

B The exam has 30 questions in 40 minutes, plus a short NDA and tutorial

As published for PCEP-30-02.

C The passing score is 70%

As published for PCEP-30-02.

D There is a scheduled break halfway through

The PCEP exam has no scheduled breaks.

THE SIGNAL

No notes, no breaks, 30 questions, 40 minutes, 70%. Now the practice papers.